

INSATIABLE
My Hunger For Life
By Shobhaa De
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
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IN maturity, writers often acquire a certain hard-earned insouciance, the kind that cannot be readily taught or mimicked—and God knows Shobhaa De has had a legion of imitators. Across the 75-year-old writer's long and distinguished career, people have tried to copy her style. Journalists have tried and failed to capture the bite and pizzazz of her best columns. Novelists have tried to channel the candour and the optimal salaciousness of her best fictions. It's tough to beat the original, however, and De's latest, a book of loosely structured autobiographical vignettes called *Insatiable* (published by HarperCollins India), proves that all over again.

In these pages, one finds De meeting a wide array of people, several prominent writers, artists and filmmakers among them. Dinners, professional engagements, or chance encounters, De remains a gifted raconteur and her recollections of these meetings are, as always, quite entertaining. During an online interview, De spoke about the book's gestation period, so to speak. "I've been writing a diary since I was 14," she said. "But it's not really a very rigorous account of everything I see and do, it's more to do with how I feel about things. So, I'd say it was a force of habit and it wasn't really difficult for me to summon the details that you see in the book's anecdotes."

De's dispatches on Bollywood, of course, are famous and this book, too, has its fair share of encounters with actors and filmmakers. One of my favourite sections in this context sees De having dinner at Aamir Khan's house with the actor's family. This is De at her chatty, conversational best, delivering short, sharp sketches of her subject, like this succinct appraisal of Khan, in the book's second half. "He is pretty radical in the choices he has made (personal and professional) and I appreciate his guts. We are not 'friends'. (Friendship is a big word. Friendship and showbiz make strange bedfellows.) However, when we do meet, I enjoy talking to him. He reads a lot, is interested in several subjects beyond Bollywood, and he gets into a great deal of trouble. To me, that is the best part. By refusing to follow the pack and remain politically correct, Aamir Khan has paid a price."

Other amusing episodes include De meeting a young writer she knows at a well-known bookstore. The writer was having a mini-meltdown because his books were not prominently displayed. She tried to play it down, saying she seldom looks for her own books in stores. The younger man snaps back, "Of course you wouldn't, you're Shobhaa De, the rest of us have to do this." De, though taken aback by the incident, admits the truth of this statement despite the rudeness. It's a charming, revelatory little passage about the lives that writers lead. When I asked her about the incident during our interview, De struck a philosophical note.

"At the end of the day, you're just another writer in a world full of books and the world isn't going to stop revolving because you have another book out," De said. "I understand being young and ambitious, of course, and I think it's great that this young writer cares about his career so much. I think he's really talented and will go a long way but I think in that moment, he could have been a little less obvious, a bit less crass in handling the situation."

At the beginning of the book, De likens the narrative to a food court, noting the different 'flavours' of the episodes recalled within its pages. Indeed, we meet a great many kinds of dinner guests at De's table—aloof, vivacious, unpredictable or simple-hearted. And then there were genuine outliers like the late artist M.F.

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